

capsule, and an orbiter. The capsule was equipped with all that would be needed for a manned flight.

Although modelled after the Soyuz, it is considered much safer due to a number of technological advances to the launch vehicle and the launch escape system, deemed critical following the Columbia disaster.

The improved launch escape system allows the crew to escape the pod before liftoff via cables, high-speed elevator, or ejection seats. The escape tower can fire to pull the capsule and orbital module away from the booster in the event of a major booster malfunction from 15 minutes before launch to the point of escape tower jettison at approximately T+120 seconds. The escape tower can be activated automatically by the fault monitoring system or by ground control or manually by the astronauts. Additionally, the escape pod is equipped with improved life-support systems for the crew.

The chosen booster rocket was the Long March-2F, which consists of two core stages, a payload fairing, an escape tower, and four liquid-fuel, strap-on boosters. The rocket has improved guidance and control equipment, upgraded engines, a fault monitoring management system, and its craft shell has been reinforced to withstand greater extremes of heat and vibration.

After three more successful tests, it was deemed safe to send a taikonaut on board. Shenzhou 5 was the fifth spacecraft in the series and the first to contain a human presence. The spacecraft, manned by Lt. Col. Yang Liwei, was launched on October 15, 2003. Liwei orbited the Earth for nearly 21.5 hours before landing in the grasslands of Inner Mongolia. While in orbit, the taikonaut dined on specially prepared versions of Chinese food, talked with his wife and son, and took a three hour nap in addition to performing various planned activities. A total of 14 orbits were made.



Yang Liwei, the first Chinese 'taikonaut' to fly into space on an indigenously made spacecraft

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With the Shenzhou 5, China became only the third nation in history